

Spinach, tomato, and cucumber salad with garlic croutons

Trying to get the kids to eat salad? They might like this one. I've included Russian dressing as one choice; because it has ketchup in it, they very well might go for it. You might too if you have a **craving** for the good old days of mayonnaise and ketchup. By the way, the croutons are extra special, so don't leave them out.

½ loaf of slightly stale French or Italian bread

6 tablespoons olive oil

5 large garlic cloves, thinly sliced

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1 large cucumber

1 bunch of fresh spinach (⅔ to 1 pound), tough stems removed, thoroughly washed, torn into bite-size pieces [300 to 500g]

2 large ripe tomatoes, seeded and cut into chunks

CHOOSE YOUR DRESSING

Creamy Fresh Herb Dressing (recipe follows)

Russian Dressing with Sun-Dried Tomatoes (recipe on page 291)

1. Preheat the oven to 375°F [190°C]. Cut the bread into thick slices, then into fat cubes. If not stale, leave in a bowl overnight or lightly toast in the oven.
2. In a large cast-iron or other ovenproof skillet, heat the olive oil over medium-low heat. Add the garlic and cook until it just begins to brown. Immediately remove with a slotted spoon and set the toasted garlic aside.
3. Add the bread cubes to the oil in the skillet and quickly stir with a spoon so as many cubes are coated with oil as possible. Continue to cook, stirring, for 1 or 2 minutes. Season lightly with salt and pepper.

4. Transfer the skillet to the preheated oven and bake for 10 to 15 minutes, until the croutons are crisp and nicely browned. **Toss** the toasted garlic with the croutons. Let cool and set aside. If you not using all of the croutons, seal the remainder in a plastic bag and store in a cool place.
5. **Peel** the cucumber, cut it lengthwise in half, and scoop out the seeds. Cut the cucumber into slices—thick or thin, as you prefer.
6. In a large bowl, toss the cucumber slices, spinach, and tomatoes. Add 3 or 4 tablespoons of the dressing and toss again. **Season** with salt and pepper to taste. Top with the croutons and garlic and serve. Pass the remaining dressing on the side.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Creamy fresh herb dressing

In this luscious dressing, tofu is used for the base, citrus as a conduit for flavor, and the herbs for an accent. Really, there is no wrong way to make this recipe. The options are wide open. Use whatever fruit and fresh herbs you have on hand.

4 ounces silken tofu [125g]

¼ cup fresh citrus juice (any combination of orange, lime, tangerine, and lemon) [60ml]

1 tablespoon chopped mixed fresh herbs (lemon thyme, mint, basil, tarragon)

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1½ tablespoons red wine vinegar or cider vinegar

Vegetable stock or water (optional)

Salt and freshly ground pepper

Puree the tofu, citrus juice, herbs, olive oil, and vinegar in a blender or food processor until very smooth. Add a little vegetable stock or water if you like a thinner consistency. Season with salt and pepper to taste. If you have time, let the dressing stand for at least 1 hour before serving to let the flavors develop.

MAKES ABOUT 1 CUP [250ML]